

also give you greater confidence that you can find a tenant to rent out the property if you retain it as an investment. Running a car for your commute is less of an impost when you have a humble mortgage, but some homeowners can tootle to the area's nearest train station and jump aboard for the rest of the journey, and you can find townships that have workers' shuttle buses to the city during peak times.

How to find this type of property

Make a hit list and hit the road, spending a weekend in each town or district, attending 'open for inspections' to get a feel for what your money will get, as much as getting a feel for the culture and sense of community. If you're pressed for time, find a buyers' advocate who, for a fee, will do the search for you within your budget and list of desires. Buyers' advocates are also handy for assisting you to find a property with long-term investment – that is, rental – potential. When you've narrowed down the search, long before making a bid or an offer on that romantic cottage with chooks scratching in the yard, book a local Airbnb or a motel room for a week in that town and experience the daily commute into your workplace. You might decide that, for all the fresh air and country hospitality, you bloody hate travelling back and forth. Know this before you're locked into a contract.

6. A new, off-the-plan apartment

Must have: A developer and associated builder with a respectable track record.

Why? New apartments are often built in inner-city locations where the lifestyle is vibrant, and they carry stamp duty savings in some states. A buyer can generally pay a five to ten per cent deposit to the developer when signing the deal, and then the balance on settlement – which can be a couple of years down the track, allowing time to accumulate savings.

There are risks and rewards in buying off-the-plan, which means the apartments are yet to be built and you're purchasing on spec. The apartment construction boom – and affordability crisis in some capital cities – has